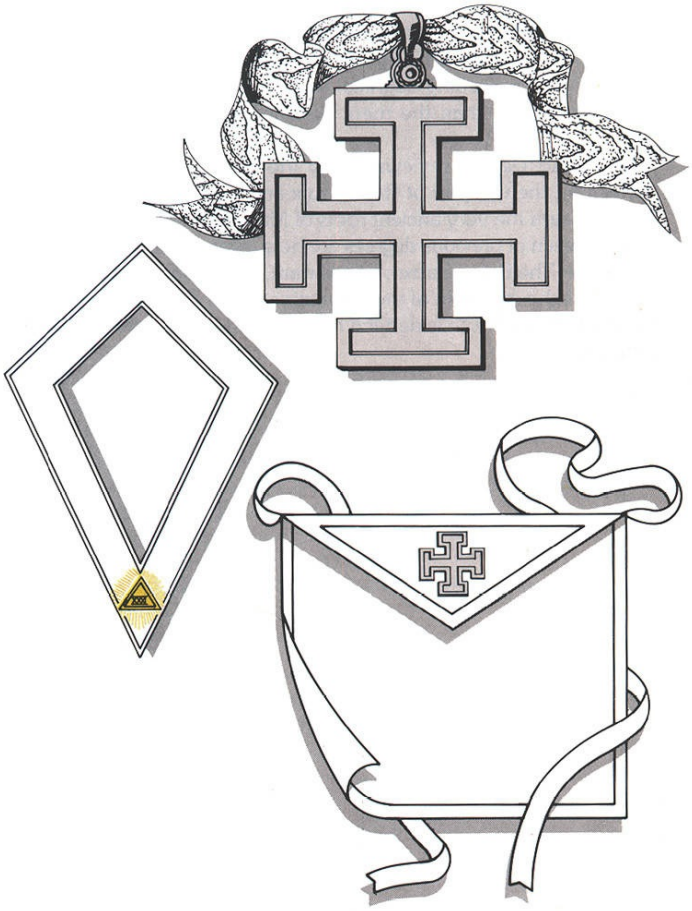
# CONSISTORY

# Introduction to the Consistory Degrees

The Consistory Degrees are the 31st and 32nd. They are very different in form and content. The 31st Degree reveals the dynamic relationship that has existed for centuries between human law as a means of achieving justice and divine justice as an ideal. It asks all of us to judge ourselves in the light of this knowledge and the lessons of the preceding degrees. It teaches us that the path to immortality is more than the mere outward appearance of piety.

The 32nd Degree reviews briefly the degrees of the Lodge of Perfection, the Chapter of Rose Croix and the Council of Kadosh. In it, we learn the very ancient roots of Masonic Truth– in the East. Symbols seen in previous degrees are here given broader and deeper meanings. The Royal Secret, Equilibrium, is explained in this degree and forms the capstone of the instruction of the Scottish Rite. From this fundamental truth is derived human wisdom and virtue or right conduct.

# The 31st Degree – Inspector Inquisitor



Though no apron is worn in the Tribunal, there was an apron that was to be worn when an Inspector Inquisitor visited an inferior body. That custom has been dispensed with but the apron is still a part of the history and symbolism of the degree; so it is displayed here. It is of pure white lambskin with a Teutonic Cross embroidered in black and silver upon the flap.

The collar is white and at the point upon the breast is a gold triangle emitting rays with the letters “xxxi” in the center.

The jewel of the degree is a Teutonic Cross of silver worn with a white watered ribbon around the neck.

DUTIES

*Judge yourself in the same light as you judge others consider both actions and motives.*

LESSONS

*The good man is able to portray himself and his actions positively and not simply assert the absence of wrong in his life.*

*Justice and mercy are two opposites which unite in the great harmony of equity.*

*To aim at the best but be content with the best possible is true wisdom.*

FOR REFLECTION

*Is the man a thief who steals a loaf of bread for his hungry children?*

IMPORTANT SYMBOLS

*Balance, heart, columns, sages, Tetractys.*

In many of the previous degrees and particularly in *Morals and Dogma,* references to classic Egyptian religion and philosophy are made, but it is only here that we see the elaborate costuming and furnishings from this heritage. The leading feature of the Egyptian religion was its emphasis on eternal existence, reflected clearly in the majestic pyramids, mummification and numerous talismans. The most important of these was the scarab, a beetle symbolic of immortality. Descriptions of these artifacts and their importance to ancient Egypt are found in the lengthy scrolls of papyrus compiled under the title *The Book of the Dead.*

The Book of the Dead is composed of some two thousand papyrus rolls found in various tombs, all of which contain formulas to guide the dead in their journey to everlasting peace in the realm of the gods. The title of these scrolls is more appropriately translated from the Egyptian as “manifested in the light,” or “coming forth by day” a second title is best translated “the chapter of making strong (or perfect) the Khu” (Budge, p. xxx).

There is a long tradition which connects modern speculative Freemasonry with the teachings of the ancient Egyptians. Dozens of books have been written which stress this association. Some scholars have even theorized that speculative Freemasonry originated in Egypt. The actual historical connections which confirm this theory are entirely lacking. Whatever importance is assigned the

Egyptian heritage in Masonry, our concern here is a path to immortality which the Egyptians elaborated and illustrated in their writings in a dramatic fashion.

## CEREMONY

The prelude to this degree is set in a darkened cave, the walls of which have scenes from the Court of the Dead and panels of hieroglyphics. An older knight is seated on a rock with a lantern studying the figures. A young squire enters and the two begin a discussion. With youthful zeal the squire deprecates these as nonsensical “scribblings,” adding that “it would be better that their so–called art be cut from these walls and ground into mortar to build a church.” The older seneschal attempts to temper the youthful squire by remarking that “men too often seek to destroy that which they do not understand.” Then, “setting the stage” for the reception, the seneschal invites the squire to listen, as they are quietly transported back in time.

The Degree takes place in a re–creation of the Court of the Dead in Egyptian mythology, a place where judgment is rendered on the worthiness of a recently deceased man to enter into the kingdom of the gods. It relies heavily on *The Book of the Dead*.

**The Hall of Justice.** The Egyptians believed that aspects of a man’s *ka,* or double, could be seen in the material world. Such was the explanation given for a man’s shadow or–his reflection in a mirror. These physical manifestations of the ka were, to them, evidence of its existence. They believed that the ka accompanied the body to the Abode of the Dead to be there judged and to answer for both virtues and vices of life.

In the land of Chemi, there lived an architect whose name was Cheres, the character assumed by the candidate. When he passed away, his *ka* descended with his body to the Abode of the Dead for judgment. We now follow him on his journey and enter the Court of the Dead to see what this man’s end will be.

In the East is a transparency of a winged globe with two serpents. In the center of the Hall is a large balance. In one pan is a vase, heart shaped, and in the other

is a figure of Ma, goddess of truth and justice. The heart shaped vase represents the deeds of the soul when it dwelt within the body. West of the balance is a funeral bier with a representation of a corpse upon it, swathed like a mummy with a skull cap and the seed vessel of a lotus plant near the head. Near each corner of the Hall is a small table upon which is a censer for burning perfume. For the Egyptians this was the Hall of Two Truths, the meaning of which will soon be explained.

**The Egyptian deities present in the hall are:**

1. Osiris: the Lord and Judge of the dead;
2. Atum: called the “Father of Souls”;
3. Ma (or Maat): goddess of Truth and Justice whose image weighs upon one side of the balance;
4. Thoth: Scribe of the gods;
5. Anubis: Conductor of Souls; son of Osiris by his sister Nephthys;
6. Horus: son of Osiris, who presents the deceased to his father;
7. Isis: wife and sister of Osiris, mother of Horus;
8. Nephthys: sister of Isis and Osiris, mother of Anubis by Osiris;
9. Four sons of Horus—Kebehsenuef, Duamutef, Hapi and Imsety.

The candidate is brought into the Court of the Dead to be judged for actions while living and to determine if he deserves to dwell among the gods. His escort is Horus. Isis, Horus’ mother, speaks first, inquiring whose ka has come to be judged. The candidate announces his readiness to be judged; he is warned of the consequences of an unfavorable judgment:

> ***they do not behold the great Amun–Ra. Their eyes do not drink in the rays that flow from his being. Their souls shall not be manifested or made illustrious in the world. They shall not hear the voice of this great god, who is exalted far above their sphere.***

Favorable judgment promises:

***to those … the great god speaks, and they speak to him. His glory illuminates them in the splendor of his being. They shall enter into the realm of light.***

Through Horus, the candidate claims to have led the most virtuous of lives. The gods express their hope that he speaks the truth. They ask him to approach the balance and stand near the body that was his in life.

Atum speaks first, inquiring who stands here to be judged. Once again Horus, speaking for the candidate, recites his virtuous life. Imsety acknowledges the truth of his claim to have abided by the laws of his land; Hapi verifies his obedience to the religious requirements; Duamutef confirms his honesty in financial matters; Kebehsenuef attests to his fidelity; and Thoth answers that he has recorded all of the assertions of outward virtue and their confirmations.

Atum directs that these merits be placed upon the balance. The pan is lifted only slightly from the floor; thus the outward virtues are deemed insufficient to justify the entrance of this deceased man into the abode of the gods.

Horus asks Osiris, his father, to allow further questions, whereby to judge the deceased. Isis and Nephthys, sisters, arise and stand at each end of the bier upon which the body rests. Then Isis moves to the altar of Amun–Ra and, admonishing the candidate on the importance of truth, puts to him five questions on his morality which he answers one–by–one. Suspecting that he may have answered them only to his best advantage, she gives him an opportunity to change any answers that, upon reflection, were not entirely truthful. Thoth confirms that he has recorded all of the answers.

Before the altar of Kneph, Nephthys prepares to interrogate the deceased about his religious piety. Following prayer, she puts five questions to him while Thoth dutifully records his answers.

Isis now directs the candidate to the altar of the great god Khem, the source of life. Here she inquires about the honesty of the deceased through five questions. Thoth again records the answers.

Now before the altar of Ptah, the Artificer of the World, Nephthys inquires into the soul's selfishness, or lack of it, by five questions of such a nature; the answers are again recorded by the Scribe of the gods.

The answers to all of the specific questions before the altars of various deities are now thrown upon the balance, making the pans nearly equal. The opinions of the Assessors are collected; Thoth reports that a majority believe this man worthy to dwell with the gods, but that some do not. Some of the gods side with the majority of the Assessors and some with the minority.

Osiris, having once been a man and subject to the passions and weaknesses of human existence, knows that the other gods cannot appreciate human fallibility. He renders the final judgment—this man is worthy of admittance into the realm of everlasting light and rest and peace.

Now we may understand the meaning of the name, Hall of Two Truths—there is that truth of our conduct during our life; there is also that absolute truth which takes no account of our excuses and rationalizations but presents before us, without any veil, the stark facts of our conduct. These two truths express themselves in negative and positive affirmations: we may negatively deny having done some wrong or we may positively assert that we have performed some service for good. The historian and philosopher Will Durant provides an example of the mode of denial expressed in the *Egyptian Book of the Dead*:

> *... the soul was to declare its innocence of all major sins in a ‚negative confession" that represents for us one of the earliest and noblest expressions of the moral sense in man: ... I have not committed iniquity against men. I have not oppressed the poor. ... I have not starved any man, ... I have not committed treason against any. ... I have not blasphemed. ... I have not falsified the balance. ... I am pure* (*Durant*, Vol. 1, pp. 203–204).

The essential lesson of this allegory cautions us not to mistake form for substance: we may obey all the laws of our society only from fear of retribution, practice such charity as is convenient and not discomfiting and attend church regularly to be seen doing so by our neighbors. All the outward manifestations of

civility and piety do not suffice the really good man. His adherence to the laws of his society are from the respect he has for their moral worth, his charity is painful to himself and his religion is scrupulously private. Such men are striving toward perfection, being the best that they can be, ever seeking better ways to serve their families, their nation and their fellow man. Such are truly the souls worthy to dwell in the Realm of Light.

In the Egyptian Court of the Dead, we learn the lesson of self–judgment, examining not only our actions but our motives, too. We should seek compassion for ourselves for in doing so we learn to bestow it upon others.

In summary, the duty of this degree is not the judgment of men by men—it is the judgment of each man by himself. We are to seek out our own guilt and not that of others. As Inspectors Inquisitor, our duty is to inspect, or scrutinize, our own words and acts, to weigh them carefully and so becoming conscious of our faults, to endeavor to avoid them in the future. Further, a corollary duty is to inquire into our own motives, how far we deserve the honors we have won or the shame that may have come upon us, the applause or the censure of man and the favor or the displeasure of our Father who is in Heaven. Perhaps one may replace the word “Inspector” in the title with “Introspector” with regard to words and actions. Similarly, the word “Inquisitor,” being related to “inquire” counsels that we should inquire into our own motives.

## LECTURE

The Tribunals of Grand Inspector Inquisitor Commanders is the philosophical equivalent of the Supreme Court of the Scottish Rite. To them were originally given the right of judgment upon inferior bodies. Thus, we should not be surprised to see the most profound reflections on the virtue of justice found within its lecture.

The laws of man are but the pale shadows of the great and unerring Laws of Nature which are beyond all human comprehension. Justice is not only the fundamental law of the natural universe but also of the moral universe.

One great difficulty for man is to possess the perspective which allows him to understand when his laws, being contrary to divine justice, are themselves unjust and the enforcement of them but a form of legal tyranny. The Inspector Inquisitor should listen to his conscience which is a sure guide to the true moral law of justice.

**The Law of Justice:**

*The Holy Bible will remind you of your obligation; and that as you judge here below, so you will be yourself judged hereafter, by One who has not to submit, like an earthly judge, to the sad necessity of inferring the motives, intentions, and purposes of men (of which all crime essentially consists) from the uncertain and often unsafe testimony of their acts and words; as men in thick darkness grope their way, with hands outstretched before them: but before Whom every thought, feeling, impulse, and intention of every soul that now is, or ever was, or ever will be on earth is, and ever will be through the whole infinite duration of eternity, present and visible* (p. 825).

*It is entirely true to say that justice is the constitution or fundamental law of the moral Universe, the law of right, a rule of conduct for man, in all his moral relations. No doubt all human affairs (like all other affairs), must be subject to that as the law paramount; and what is right agrees therewith and stands, while what is wrong conflicts with it and falls. The difficulty is that we ever erect our notions of what is right and just into the law of justice, and insist that God shall adopt that as His law; instead of striving to learn by observation and reflection what His law is, .... We are too wise in our own conceit, and ever strive to enact our own little notions into the Universal Laws of God* (pp. 829–830).

*The Square and Compass, the Plumb and Level, are well known to you as a Mason. Upon you as a Judge, they peculiarly inculcate uprightness, impartiality, careful consideration of facts and circumstances, accuracy in judgment, and uniformity in decision. As a Judge, too, you are to bring up square work and square work only. Like a temple erected by the plumb, you are to lean neither to*

*one side nor the other. Like a building well squared and levelled, you are to be firm and steadfast in your convictions of right and justice. Like the circle swept with the compasses, you are to be true. In the scale of justice you are to weigh the facts and the law alone, nor place in either scale personal friendship or personal dislike, neither fear nor favor: and when reformation is no longer to be hoped for, you are to smite relentlessly with the sword of justice* (p. 826).

*You are to inquire also into your own heart and conduct, and keep careful watch over yourself, that you go not astray. If you harbor ill–will and jealousy, if you are hospitable to intolerance and bigotry, and churlish to gentleness and kind affections, opening wide your heart to one and closing its portals to the other, it is time for you to set in order your own temple, or else you wear in vain the name and insignia of a Mason, while yet uninvested with the Masonic nature* (p. 827).

*The ideal justice which men ever look up to and strive to rise toward, is true; but it will not be realized in this world. Yet we must approach as near to it as practicable, as we should do toward that ideal democracy that now floats before the eyes of earnest and religious men ... only taking care that we do not, in striving to reach and ascend to the impossible ideal, neglect to seize upon and hold fast to the possible actual. To aim at the best, but be content with the best possible, is the only true wisdom. To insist on the absolute right, and throw out of the calculation the important and all–controlling element of necessity, is the folly of a mere dreamer* (p. 835).